

Negotiating Identity in the Age of Generative AI: A Five-Year Longitudinal Study of Chinese Digital Painters

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Abstract

This study presents a five-year longitudinal mixed-methods study of 17 Chinese digital painters, examining how their attitudes and practices evolved in response to generative AI. Our findings reveal a trajectory from resistance and defensiveness, to pragmatic adoption, and ultimately to reflective reconstruction, shaped by strong peer pressures and shifting emotional experiences. Persistent concerns around copyright and creative labor highlight the ongoing negotiation of identity and values. This work contributes by offering rare longitudinal empirical data, advancing a theoretical lens of “identity and value negotiation,” and providing design implications for future human-AI collaborative systems.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; **Empirical studies in HCI**; **User studies**; **Collaborative interaction**.

Keywords

Generative AI, Human-AI Collaboration, Creative Practice, Longitudinal Study, Understanding People

ACM Reference Format:

Yibo Meng, Ruiqi Chen, Zhiming Liu, Xin Chen, and Jingjie Wang. 2026. Negotiating Identity in the Age of Generative AI: A Five-Year Longitudinal Study of Chinese Digital Painters. In *Proceedings of CHI 2026 Workshop on Human-AI Interaction Alignment (BIAAlign) (CHI 2026 Workshop W37)*. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 11 pages.

1 Introduction

The rise of generative artificial intelligence (AI) is rapidly reshaping creative practice [5, 9, 41]. Across domains such as illustration, concept design, music, and literature, AI systems are increasingly positioned not merely as tools, but as collaborators, advisors, and at times competitors [6, 7, 33, 47]. While these systems promise efficiency, inspiration, and expanded expressive possibilities, they also introduce tensions around authorship, originality, and the

meaning of creative labor [24, 25, 43]. These tensions raise a broader question central to Human-AI Interaction Alignment: how can AI systems align not only with task performance, but with the values, identities, and professional norms of creative practitioners?

Prior research has examined artists’ attitudes toward AI [20, 21, 34, 42], modes of human-AI collaboration [16, 37, 40, 46], and risks related to authorship and creative labor [24, 25]. These studies reveal a persistent duality: AI is viewed as both an “engine of inspiration” and a potential threat to artistic identity. However, most work relies on cross-sectional or short-term studies [16, 26, 30, 31], offering only static snapshots of what is fundamentally a dynamic process. Alignment in creative practice is unlikely to be a one-time decision; rather, it unfolds as technologies become embedded in everyday workflows and social ecosystems.

We focus on digital painters (i.e. artists working in illustration, concept design, and game or animation art) because they are among the creative communities most directly affected by generative AI. To understand how alignment evolves over time, we conducted a five-year longitudinal mixed-methods study (2021–2025) following 17 Chinese digital painters through annual surveys and in-depth interviews. This design enables us to trace not only changes in usage and attitudes, but also ongoing negotiations of identity, authorship, and professional value.

Our findings reveal a phased trajectory: initial resistance and value defense, pragmatic adoption shaped by peer and market pressures, and eventual reflective reconstruction of creative identity. Rather than converging toward stable acceptance, participants continually recalibrated what counts as meaningful authorship, originality, and human contribution. Ethical concerns like copyright and creative labor remained persistently salient, indicating that behavioral adoption does not necessarily imply normative alignment.

This work contributes to Human-AI Interaction Alignment in three ways. First, it provides rare longitudinal empirical evidence of how alignment is experienced as a socially situated and evolving process. Second, it advances a conceptual lens of identity and value negotiation to explain why apparent collaboration can coexist with deep normative tension. Third, it offers design implications for value-centered creative AI systems that foreground transparency, controllability, and support for human agency in hybrid workflows.

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2 Related Work

2.1 Normative Alignment in Creative AI

Generative AI has prompted renewed debate about whether such systems align with the normative values that underpin creative practice. Prior work shows that artists often evaluate AI not only in terms of performance, but in relation to authorship, originality, and professional identity [3, 17, 20, 43]. While some describe AI as an “engine of inspiration” that expands creative possibility [9, 47], others experience it as a disruptive force that threatens artistic legitimacy and devalues human labor [7, 22, 34].

These tensions reflect deeper questions of normative alignment: whether AI-generated outputs resonate with creators’ understandings of authenticity, intentionality, and meaningful contribution. As Bird [3] notes, artists often navigate a double bind—seeking to leverage AI’s capabilities while resisting narratives that position it as a creative equal. However, existing studies largely rely on cross-sectional methods, providing limited insight into how normative alignment evolves over time.

2.2 Interactional Alignment and Roles

Research on human–AI collaboration further highlights that alignment depends on how roles are configured within interaction. When AI is framed as an advisor, creators tend to perceive higher alignment, as decision-making authority remains human-centered [19, 40]. As a collaborator, AI may stimulate exploration and divergence, with artists appropriating unexpected outputs as creative stimuli [33, 46].

In contrast, when AI assumes a driver role—producing outputs with minimal human intervention—alignment becomes more contested. Artists frequently question whether such systems can embody holistic style, intent, or authorship [21, 35]. Misalignment in perceived authorship and control often shapes whether creators accept or reject AI outputs [13]. Yet, most research examines these configurations in short-term or lab-based contexts, leaving open how interactional alignment shifts as AI becomes embedded in everyday workflows.

2.3 Structural Alignment

Beyond individual attitudes and interactional framing, alignment is also shaped by broader structural conditions. Concerns about copyright, data provenance, and consent have become central to debates around creative AI [22, 25]. The “3C” framework (consent, credit, and compensation) captures artists’ expectations regarding fair recognition and remuneration [25].

At the same time, generative AI has intensified labor precarity. Efficiency gains may compress production cycles and reduce compensation [24, 29], compelling creators to adopt AI as a survival strategy rather than a value-aligned choice [3]. These dynamics suggest that alignment is not solely a matter of interface design or task distribution, but is entangled with economic structures and professional hierarchies.

While prior research has illuminated normative, interactional, and structural tensions, most current studies capture alignment at a single moment in time. What remains underexplored is how creators renegotiate alignment as generative AI diffuses through

creative ecosystems. Therefore, our five-year longitudinal study addresses this gap by tracing how digital painters’ relationships with AI evolve across shifting technological capabilities, peer dynamics, and market pressures.

3 Methods

We adopted a five-year longitudinal mixed-methods design (2021–2025) to examine how digital painters’ perceptions and practices around generative AI evolved over time. Longitudinal research is well-suited for capturing change, reinterpretation, and stability across repeated waves [1, 39]. At each annual wave, we combined quantitative surveys, which provided comparable measures of cognition, usage, attitudes, and concerns, with semi-structured interviews, which yielded narratives of practice and reflection. Inspired by qualitative longitudinal traditions that emphasize understanding situated practice and context rather than isolated outcomes [8, 14, 23, 27, 44], our design enabled us to trace both group-level trajectories and how creators integrated—or resisted—AI in everyday workflows.

3.1 Participants

We recruited participants in 2021 by posting calls on major Chinese social media platforms, including WeChat, Xiaohongshu, Bilibili, Baidu Tieba, and Weibo. Eligibility criteria required participants to be 18 years or older, have at least one year of digital painting experience (professional or hobby), possess basic awareness of generative AI (e.g., having heard of it), and commit to participating in a five-year longitudinal study. Individuals whose primary creative practice was non-digital (e.g., traditional painting, sculpture) or non-illustrative digital work (e.g., 3D modeling, video editing, music production) were excluded to maintain the study’s focus. Those with less than one year of experience or unwilling to commit to long-term participation were also excluded.

In this study, *digital painters* refer to artists who primarily create two-dimensional visual works using digital tools such as Photoshop, Clip Studio Paint, or Procreate. Their practice typically spans illustration, concept design, and game or animation art, where they balance artistic expression with client requirements and fast-paced production cycles. This hybrid form of creative labor positions digital painters between independent artistry and commercial design, making them among the creative communities most directly affected by generative AI.

A total of 17 participants were enrolled in 2021, serving as the baseline sample for this longitudinal study. The sample included 7 men and 10 women, aged 19–34 ($M = 26.3$, $SD = 4.37$). Participants generally had high educational backgrounds (6 postgraduate, 10 undergraduate, 1 high school). Eleven participants identified as professional digital painters (employed in game studios, publishing houses, or design firms), and six as hobbyists. All participants were recruited from mainland China and self-identified as ethnically Chinese. Their creative domains included game art, commercial illustration, concept design, anime and graphic novels, and graphic design.

Attrition across the five-year period remained within an acceptable range: 17 participants in 2021 (baseline), 15 in 2022, 13 in 2023, 10 in 2024, and 7 in 2025. All demographics are summarized in

Appendix A. This study was reviewed and approved by the ethics review board of the University of Shanghai for Science and Technology. Each participant received ¥40 per year (¥200 total across five years) as compensation for completing the annual survey and interview.

3.2 Procedure

This study was conducted across five annual waves of data collection (2021–2025). To ensure longitudinal comparability, we followed the same procedure each year. Prior to participation, all participants provided informed consent and were informed of the study’s purpose, data use, and potential implications. They were reminded of their rights to withdraw at any time without penalty and to request deletion of their data.

Each year, participants first completed a structured questionnaire (see Appendix C for full items) covering dimensions such as cognition, usage, attitudes, and concerns. This was followed by a 45–60 minute semi-structured interview in which participants reflected on their experiences with generative AI over the past year, including changes in practice, evolving attitudes, and perceived impacts on creative and professional trajectories. The full interview guide is provided in Appendix C. Interviews were conducted online via Tencent Meeting and audio recorded with consent. Recordings were transcribed into English within 48 hours and cross-checked by at least two researchers to ensure accuracy.

Survey items were self-developed in 2021 to reflect the then-emerging and largely unstandardized nature of generative AI, when validated instruments for creators’ perceptions were not available [28, 48]. We referenced prior empirical work documenting how creative practitioners articulate expectations, anxieties, perceived affordances, and professional positioning toward generative AI [10, 18, 36]. To reduce participant burden and mitigate attrition risk across repeated waves, we adopted single-item measures; prior work suggests single-item measures can be appropriate when constructs are concrete and respondent burden is a concern [2, 45]. We used a 0–10 scale to capture gradual shifts over time with higher sensitivity and an intuitive rating format. Items underwent iterative team review and pilot testing with three digital painters before deployment. To further guarantee consistency, researchers completed standardized training prior to data collection. All data were anonymized during analysis to protect participant privacy.

3.3 Data Analysis

Our analysis aimed to capture both longitudinal trajectories and cross-cutting dynamics. Following longitudinal analysis guidance [23, 27, 44], we attended to: (a) phase shifts across 2021–2025; (b) cross-cutting differences (e.g., professional status, persistent ethical concerns); (c) reinterpretations, where earlier meanings were reframed in later years; and (d) stability, where lack of change was analytically meaningful. Quantitative and qualitative strands were analyzed separately and then integrated through connection and embedding.

3.3.1 Quantitative Data Analysis. We first computed means and standard deviations for each survey item (Q1–Q12) at each wave to describe group-level patterns. To examine temporal trends, we conducted repeated measures ANOVA using complete cases across

the five waves [15]. Given attrition over time, inferential analyses were based on participants with sufficient multi-wave data, while descriptive statistics reflect all available responses at each wave. When significant main effects of time were observed, we conducted paired-samples comparisons and reported effect sizes (Cohen’s *d*) [11]. For items showing clear monotonic trends (e.g., copyright salience), we also examined linear trend components [32].

Given attrition and professional status transitions across waves, subgroup analyses were interpreted cautiously. Where professional and hobbyist trajectories are discussed or visualized, we focus on participants with relatively stable professional identities and sufficient multi-wave data. These subgroup patterns are presented descriptively to illustrate longitudinal divergence rather than to support formal inferential statistical claims.

3.3.2 Qualitative Data Analysis. All interviews were transcribed verbatim and cross-checked for accuracy. We conducted thematic analysis [4] supported by NVivo. Two researchers independently coded transcripts from two participants across all five waves to construct an initial codebook, which was iteratively refined with additional transcripts. Inter-coder agreement exceeded 80%, and disagreements were resolved through discussion until consensus.

Building on the finalized codebook, we created longitudinal case files for each participant and conducted synchronous coding across their five years of data to trace narrative development, reinterpretation, and stability over time [23, 27, 44]. Codes were then aggregated into themes and subthemes and reviewed by the broader team to ensure coherence and distinctiveness.

3.3.3 Integration of Mixed Methods. We integrated quantitative and qualitative findings via *connection* and *embedding*. Connection refers to using quantitative trends to guide deeper qualitative analysis (e.g., revisiting interviews from waves with notable shifts). Embedding refers to incorporating key quantitative figures within qualitative narratives to connect group-level trajectories with individual accounts and to surface convergence and divergence across methods.

4 Quantitative Findings

The quantitative results suggest that participants’ attitudes toward generative AI in digital painting evolved in three phases. In 2021–2022, attitudes turned sharply negative, reaching their lowest point in 2022. In 2023–2024, evaluations improved markedly across dimensions such as perceived aesthetic value (e.g., style reproduction), tool utility, inspiration, and willingness to learn, with professionals generally showing stronger acceptance than hobbyists. By 2025, attitudes largely stabilized, remaining positive but without further significant gains.

4.1 Early Resistance (2021–2022)

The years 2021–2022 marked the early stage of generative AI’s emergence in digital painting communities. During this period, participants reported limited knowledge and minimal use, yet their overall evaluations became more negative as visibility and experimentation increased. Figure 1 shows that in 2021 the mean score for Q1 (self-reported understanding of generative AI principles) was 2.82 (*SD* = 1.07), while Q2 (frequency of using generative AI

in creative work) was near zero at 0.06 ($SD = 0.24$). Consistent with this, Figure ?? shows that only P1 (a professional painter) reported a nonzero usage score (1), while others reported 0. By 2022, these measures increased to 4.00 ($SD = 0.93$) for Q1 and 1.33 ($SD = 0.72$) for Q2. Paired-samples tests indicated that both increases were significant (Q1: $t(16) = -2.94, p = .010, d = 0.71$; Q2: $t(16) = -9.46, p < .001, d = 2.30$), suggesting that participants began to engage more actively with generative AI and developed a clearer understanding of how it works.

Attitudinal responses, however, moved in the opposite direction. Overall attitude toward applying generative AI to creative work (Q12) declined from 2.18 ($SD = 1.51$) in 2021 to 1.20 ($SD = 1.37$) in 2022 ($t(16) = 2.36, p = .031, d = -0.57$). Willingness to learn (Q6) also decreased from 2.29 ($SD = 1.05$) to 1.73 ($SD = 1.44$) ($t(16) = 2.60, p = .019, d = -0.63$), and the sharpest drop occurred in future outlook (Q11), from 2.06 ($SD = 1.34$) to 0.93 ($SD = 1.03$) ($t(16) = 4.22, p = .001, d = -1.02$). In other words, participants became more knowledgeable and exploratory, yet their assessments of AI's value grew more negative. This divergence suggests early *misalignment* between growing familiarity and perceived legitimacy or trust.

Responses to risk-related items also reflected heightened caution (Figure 2). For example, Q8 (belief about AI's influence on professional competitiveness; reverse-scored) increased from 6.65 ($SD = 2.12$) in 2021 to 7.73 ($SD = 1.71$) in 2022 ($t(16) = -3.44, p = .003, d = 0.83$), indicating greater concern about competitive pressures. Other items such as Q7 (homogenization and loss of individual style) and Q9 (reduced market demand) increased numerically, though not all reached statistical significance. Together, these results characterize 2021–2022 as a phase of suspicion and resistance, rather than straightforward rejection: participants experimented more, but evaluated AI more negatively as its implications became salient.

4.2 Rapid Adoption (2022–2024)

Between 2022 and 2024, participants' overall evaluations improved markedly. Scores on Q12 (overall attitude) rose from 1.20 ($SD = 1.37$) in 2022 to 5.07 ($SD = 1.49$) in 2023 ($t(16) = -9.65, p < .001, d = 2.34$), and further to 8.07 ($SD = 1.21$) in 2024 ($t(16) = -6.73, p < .001, d = 1.63$). This indicates a clear positive shift, suggesting that early skepticism gave way to pragmatic acceptance as generative AI became more available and more actionable within creative routines.

As shown in Figure 1, this improvement extended across multiple dimensions. For instance, Q3 (perceived ability to reproduce artistic style/expressions) rose from 0.33 ($SD = 0.62$) in 2022 to 2.73 ($SD = 1.67$) in 2023, and to 6.43 ($SD = 1.95$) in 2024 (both year-to-year increases significant at $p < .001$). Similar upward trends appeared in Q4 (AI as an auxiliary creative tool), Q5 (AI as a source of inspiration), Q6 (willingness to learn), and Q11 (future outlook). Notably, Q5 increased strongly between 2023 and 2024 ($t(16) = -12.16, p < .001, d = 2.95$), reflecting a broad shift toward recognizing AI's creative affordances.

In parallel, perceived risks declined substantially (Figure 2). Q7 (homogenization concern; reverse-scored) decreased from 7.40 ($SD = 1.72$) in 2022 to 5.13 ($SD = 1.60$) in 2023 and to 2.57 ($SD = 1.60$) in 2024 (2022–2023: $t(16) = 5.80, p < .001, d = -1.41$; 2023–2024:

$t(16) = 4.11, p = .001, d = -1.00$). Comparable downward trajectories were observed for Q8 and Q9. Overall, the 2022–2024 period reflects a rapid adoption phase characterized by expanding engagement and a shift toward *pragmatic alignment*: participants increasingly treated generative AI as an actionable component of workflow, while some deeper concerns remained to be interpreted qualitatively (Section 5).

4.3 Stabilization (2024–2025)

From 2024 to 2025, participants' evaluations remained largely stable. Q12 showed a small decrease from 8.07 ($SD = 1.21$) to 7.57 ($SD = 1.83$) that did not reach significance ($t(16) = 1.75, p = .099, d = -0.43$). Similar non-significant declines appeared for Q3 (style reproduction) and Q6 (willingness to learn) ($p > .05$). By contrast, Q1 (self-reported understanding) increased slightly from 7.36 ($SD = 1.22$) to 7.57 ($SD = 1.79$) ($t(16) = -0.26, p = .797$). Risk-related items (Q7–Q9) also exhibited no significant year-to-year differences.

This period can be interpreted as a stabilization stage following rapid adoption. Attitudes remained highly positive but plateaued, suggesting that novelty-driven enthusiasm gave way to a more consistent and pragmatic evaluation. In other words, generative AI appeared to be normalized in participants' workflows, and evaluations consolidated rather than continued to accelerate (see Section 5 for qualitative context).

4.4 Persistent Attention to AI Ethics

Unlike the cyclical fluctuations observed in many other dimensions, participants consistently rated copyright and authorship concerns as highly important. Scores on Q10 increased from 7.82 ($SD = 1.24$) in 2021 to 8.40 ($SD = 1.24$) in 2022 and 9.07 ($SD = 0.88$) in 2023, reaching 9.57 ($SD = 0.51$) in 2024 and remaining at that level in 2025. A linear trend analysis confirmed that this increase was significant (slope = 0.47, $R^2 = .93, p = .008$). These results suggest that even as perceptions of AI's creative utility improved, ethical salience remained stable and became an integral part of participants' overall assessment of generative AI.

4.5 Professional Status and Attitudinal Differences

As shown in Figures 3–5, professional digital painters and hobbyists exhibited systematic differences in their trajectories. Overall, professionals reported higher acceptance and more positive growth over time, whereas hobbyists showed comparatively modest improvements and higher residual concern.

Importantly, because attrition and professional status transitions occurred over the five-year period, the professional–hobbyist visualizations are reported *descriptively*. Specifically, Figures 3 and 4 visualize an analytic subset of participants selected for relatively stable professional identities and sufficient multi-wave data (Professionals: P1, P2, P6, P11, P15; Hobbyists: P4, P12, P13). Figure 5 includes an additional illustrative participant (User 14) for visualization completeness. These figures are intended to highlight longitudinal divergence rather than serve as the basis for formal inferential subgroup claims.

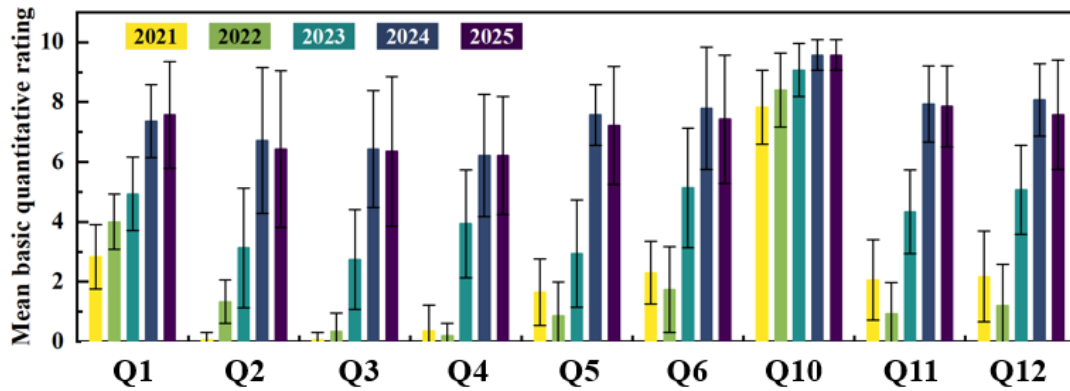


Figure 1: Mean and Standard Deviation of Participants' Scores across Five Waves (2021–2025) on Nine Positively Scored Dimensions.

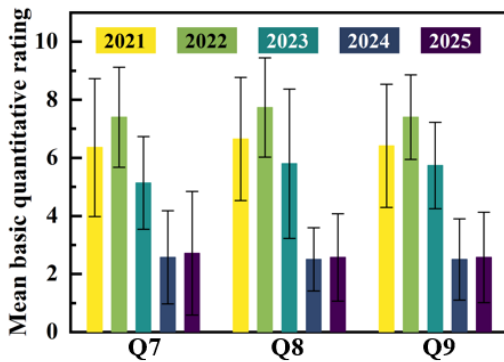


Figure 2: Mean and Standard Deviation of Participants' Scores across Five Waves (2021–2025) on Three Reverse-Scored Dimensions.

Across positively scored items (Figure 3), professionals consistently reported higher ratings than hobbyists from 2021 to 2025, with gaps widening in later years. For example, on Q12 (overall attitude), professionals approached an average close to 8 by 2025, compared to around 6 among hobbyists. Similar patterns appear for Q5 (AI as inspiration) and Q6 (willingness to learn), suggesting stronger recognition of AI's practical and creative value among professionals.

Conversely, across risk-related items (Figure 4), professionals generally reported lower scores than hobbyists, indicating lower perceived threat. For example, by 2025, concern about reduced market demand (Q9; reverse-scored) was approximately 2.5 among professionals, compared to nearly 4 among hobbyists. Taken together, these descriptive patterns suggest professional context as an important factor shaping alignment and adoption trajectories. However, given the small and selective analytic subset and the descriptive nature of these visualizations, these differences should be interpreted as indicative rather than conclusive. Section 5 further

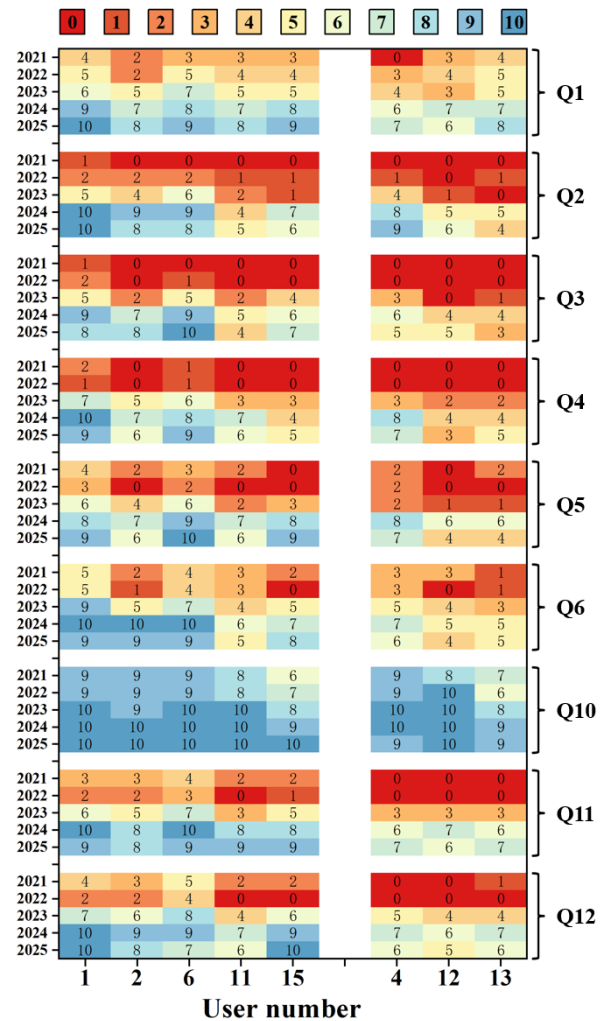


Figure 3: Attitudes of Professionals (left) and Hobbyists (right) toward AI-assisted drawing on positively scored items.

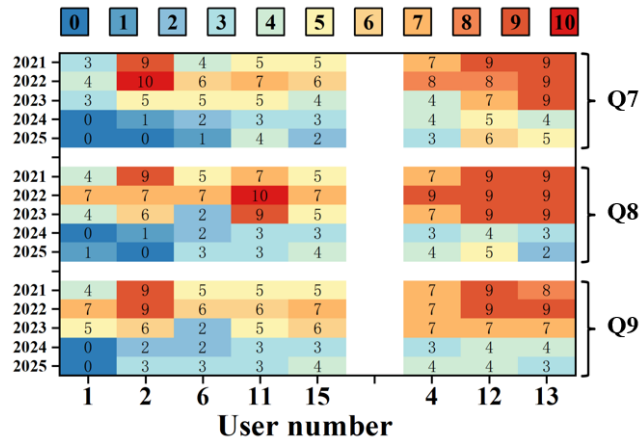


Figure 4: Attitudes of Professionals (left) and Hobbyists (right) toward AI-assisted drawing on negatively scored items.

examines occupational mechanisms—including workflow embedding, economic dependence, and peer community pressures—that help explain why these trajectories diverged.

5 Qualitative Findings

The qualitative data reveal that painters’ engagement with generative AI was not merely a matter of technological adoption, but a prolonged negotiation over legitimacy, authorship, and professional meaning. Across five years, participants moved through three distinguishable phases—strong resistance (2021–2022), instrumental and pragmatic adoption (2022–2024), and identity reconstruction (2025).

Importantly, these phases were not driven solely by improvements in model capability. Instead, they reflected shifting interpretations of what AI represented within participants’ creative, economic, and social worlds. While the quantitative results capture changes in attitude intensity, the qualitative narratives illuminate why these shifts occurred and how painters redefined their relationship with AI over time.

5.1 Longitudinal Trajectory of Attitudes

5.1.1 Strong Resistance (2021–2022). Between 2021 and 2022, participants moved from tentative curiosity to entrenched resistance toward generative AI. In 2021, many described themselves as “testing the waters”—interested but uncertain. Several downloaded early AI applications or experimented with demo websites, but treated them as novelties rather than serious tools. As P3 recalled, “I played with it for fun, just to see what it could do. At that time it felt like a toy, not something that could threaten me” (2021).

By 2022, however, as AI-generated images circulated widely on social media and art forums, the tone shifted dramatically. What had seemed harmless became perceived as invasive. Participants frequently dismissed outputs as “garbage,” “worthless collages,” or “devoid of artistic sensibility.” P1 reflected: “Everyone is posting AI

art everywhere, and to me they all look the same—shallow, soulless” (2022).

The most common criticism concerned perceived artistic shallowness. P9 explained: “Maybe they look polished, but they have no warmth. Real art always carries traces of the artist’s struggle, and these images erase that struggle” (2022). These reactions indicate that resistance was rooted less in technical deficiency and more in perceived absence of human intentionality.

A second critique targeted creativity itself. Ten participants emphasized that creativity is inherently human. As P12 argued, “Can patching things together really count as creativity?” (2022). Closely tied to this was anxiety about authorship erosion. P14 asked: “If people can’t tell the difference, what does my signature mean anymore?” (2022).

Copyright concerns intensified distrust. P7 worried about dataset scraping, while P2 framed it as economic threat: “It’s not just unfair—it’s stealing my future opportunities” (2022).

In this phase, resistance stemmed from perceived violations of artistic norms. AI was seen as bypassing effort, obscuring authorship, and destabilizing symbolic recognition. The rejection was therefore identity-driven and moral rather than purely aesthetic. Increased familiarity did not alleviate suspicion; instead, greater visibility intensified perceived threat.

5.1.2 Instrumental and Pragmatic Adoption (2022–2024). Between 2022 and 2024, participants’ attitudes shifted from categorical rejection to conditional incorporation. Rather than viewing AI as an artistic rival, many began to frame it as a functional instrument embedded within their workflows.

This transition is visible in the language used during interviews. In 2022, transcripts were filled with strongly negative descriptors; by 2023 and 2024, those expressions largely disappeared and were replaced by references to efficiency, reference value, and practical usefulness. The shift did not imply full endorsement of AI as a creative agent, but rather a redefinition of its role.

Improvements in output quality played an important role in this reframing. Several participants acknowledged that AI-generated images had become visually compelling, even if they still questioned their creative authenticity. As P6 reflected, “I saved many AI-generated characters... their color schemes look appealing” (2023). AI outputs were increasingly treated as visual resources or reference material rather than finished artworks.

For professionals in particular, economic considerations became decisive. The acceleration of production cycles made AI difficult to ignore. P10 stated, “What takes me ten days, AI can finish in a minute” (2024). Even participants who remained skeptical adopted AI selectively in order to maintain competitiveness. Efficiency, rather than artistic admiration, drove much of this incorporation.

Participants also began using AI during early-stage conceptualization. P15 described generating rough sketches to facilitate client communication. In this sense, AI functioned as an ideation scaffold—expanding exploratory space without fully replacing human authorship. Generated outputs were often treated as drafts, prompts, or raw material to be refined manually.

Crucially, this phase did not represent a transformation in artistic values. Instead, painters redefined AI’s role in ways that preserved human control. AI was positioned as a controllable instrument

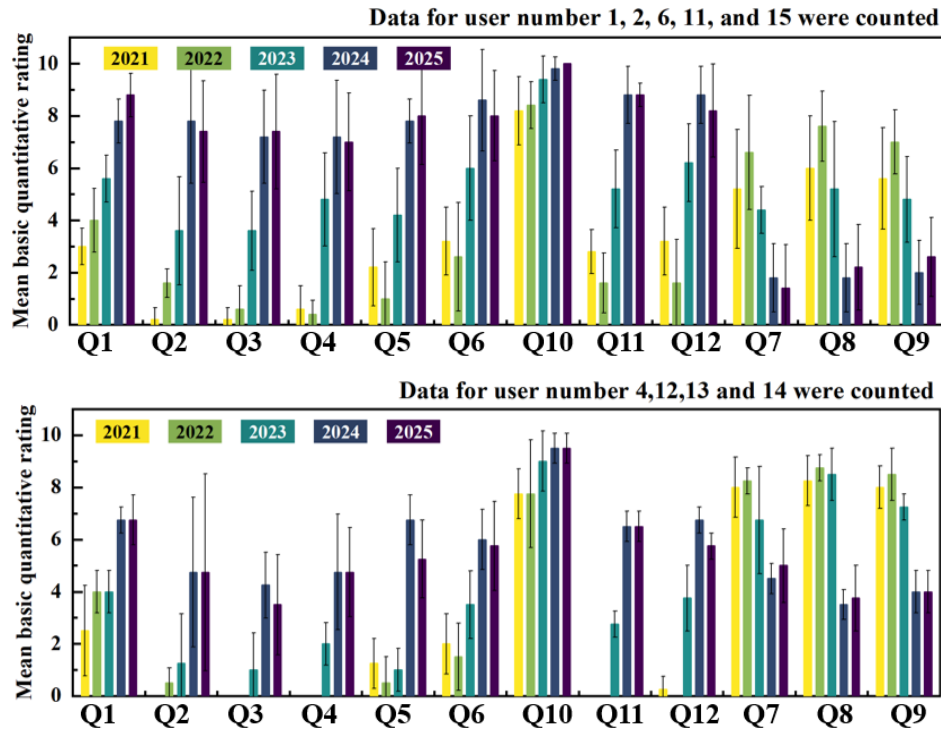


Figure 5: Mean quantitative ratings of Professional Artists (top, Users 1, 2, 6, 11, and 15) and Hobbyist Artists (bottom, Users 4, 12, 13, and 14) across 2021–2025.

within human-led processes, not as an autonomous creative authority. Adoption occurred through role adjustment rather than ideological conversion.

5.1.3 Identity Reconstruction and Reflective Reconsideration (2025). By 2025, enthusiasm had cooled and participants began reflecting more critically on the longer-term implications of AI. Rather than debating output quality, discussions centered on livelihood, artistic meaning, and personal identity.

Several professionals reported shrinking compensation or heightened job insecurity. Increased productivity did not necessarily translate into increased recognition or pay. What had previously been framed as efficiency now appeared as labor compression. Participants began to question whether technological acceleration benefited artists themselves.

At the same time, aesthetic perceptions shifted. While earlier phases emphasized rapid improvement in quality, many participants now described AI imagery as overly polished or emotionally hollow. P13 noted that outputs felt “too perfect,” lacking the traces of human effort that give artwork texture and depth. Repetition and saturation contributed to a sense of fatigue rather than fascination.

Most significantly, participants actively renegotiated authorship boundaries. Some restricted AI use to early ideation stages; others developed hybrid workflows that combined manual sketching with AI-assisted coloring while retaining final decision-making authority. These strategies reflect intentional boundary-setting rather than passive adaptation.

By this stage, the core question had shifted from whether AI could create to what remained distinctly human within creation. Painters no longer positioned AI purely as threat or tool, but as a persistent presence requiring ongoing negotiation of meaning, authorship, and value.

5.2 Cross-Cutting Themes

5.2.1 Peer Influence and Social Negotiation. Adoption trajectories were deeply social. In 2022, experimentation was often driven by peer pressure rather than intrinsic curiosity. By 2023–2024, AI sharing became normalized within communities. By 2025, peer groups became polarized between full rejection and enthusiastic embrace. These dynamics demonstrate that engagement was co-constructed through collective sensemaking rather than determined solely by individual evaluation.

5.2.2 Emotional and Experiential Shifts. Emotional responses evolved alongside cognitive and practical changes. Curiosity (2021) gave way to anger (2022), excitement (2023–2024), and eventually fatigue and reflection (2025). This affective arc shows that long-term integration of AI is not rational. Emotional experience mediated interpretation, acceptance, and boundary-setting. Engagement with AI is as both cognitive assessment and emotional negotiation.

Taken together, these findings show that longitudinal change involved continuous reinterpretation rather than linear acceptance. Painters repeatedly redefined AI’s role as its technical capacity,

social visibility, and economic implications evolved. Adoption was therefore an ongoing negotiation of meaning, control, and identity.

6 Discussion

This five-year longitudinal study shows that Chinese digital painters' engagement with generative AI cannot be described as simple adoption or rejection. Instead, it unfolded as a sustained process of identity, social, and emotional negotiation. Here, we synthesize these findings to articulate broader implications for Human-AI alignment in creative domains.

6.1 Adoption as Identity Negotiation

Traditional technology adoption models frame uptake as a gradual movement toward acceptance driven by usefulness and ease of use [12, 38]. Our findings complicate this narrative. Painters' engagement evolved through resistance, pragmatic incorporation, and reflective renegotiation—indicating that adoption is neither linear nor final.

Early resistance centered on ontological and moral concerns: whether AI-generated outputs qualified as art, and whether authorship and creative legitimacy were being undermined. As technical quality improved, opposition shifted toward instrumental use. AI was reframed as a productivity tool embedded within human-led workflows. Yet by 2025, participants were no longer debating performance; they were reconsidering distinctiveness, labor value, and authorship boundaries.

This trajectory frames adoption as an ongoing process of *identity negotiation*. This temporal process connects the daily boundary work of asserting control with the ultimate goal of normative alignment. Creators evaluate not only whether a tool functions, but whether its integration preserves professional meaning and personal distinctiveness. Alignment emerges when users reconstruct boundaries that maintain authorial agency.

6.2 Alignment as Boundary Work

A central insight from our data is that creators actively perform boundary work. Rather than deciding whether to use AI, painters increasingly negotiated how it should be positioned within their workflow. Some confined AI to ideation; others integrated it more deeply while retaining final control. These strategies indicate that alignment is not achieved by maximizing automation, but by preserving meaningful contribution boundaries.

For creative AI systems, this implies the importance of adjustable automation, transparent contribution structures, and user override. Systems that obscure authorship risk renewed resistance, even when technically advanced. In contrast, designs that foreground human agency enable integration without identity erosion.

6.3 Social and Emotional Alignment

Engagement with generative AI was socially and emotionally situated within China's specific socio-technical ecosystem. Concentrated platforms like Xiaohongshu amplified social dynamics. Furthermore, a hyper-competitive job market and fluid regional IP regulations accelerated pragmatic adoption as a survival strategy. Peer ecosystems normalized use, amplified pressure, and at times

polarized communities. Emotional trajectories shaped the depth and sustainability of engagement.

Alignment, therefore, is not purely technical calibration but a social-emotional process. Long-term integration depends on how tools sustain professional legitimacy, manage peer-induced pressure, and support emotionally sustainable interaction.

6.4 The Value of a Longitudinal Lens

Finally, our study underscores the importance of temporal perspective. A cross-sectional view in 2022 might have captured resistance; one in 2024 might have documented enthusiasm. Only longitudinal inquiry reveals the full arc of resistance, incorporation, and renegotiation. Human-AI relationships evolve alongside technological maturity and shifting social discourse. Especially in creative domains, where identity and value are central, extended temporal frameworks are essential to avoid misinterpreting transitional states as stable positions.

6.5 Reframing Human-AI Collaboration

Our findings challenge binary narratives that portray generative AI as either creative replacement or seamless collaborator. Instead, we observe negotiated coexistence. Painters did not passively adapt to AI; they reshaped workflows and redefined meaning.

Human-AI collaboration should therefore be reframed as an ongoing process of alignment through negotiation—where control, identity, and value are continuously recalibrated. In creative domains, alignment is less about optimizing performance and more about sustaining human distinctiveness within technologically augmented practice.

7 Conclusion

This paper presented a five-year longitudinal mixed-methods study of 17 digital painters in China, tracing how their attitudes toward generative AI shifted from resistance, to pragmatic adoption, and ultimately to reflective reconsideration. Our findings highlight not only these temporal trajectories but also the horizontal forces of peer influence, emotional dynamics, and persistent ethical concerns. By situating these insights within HCI, we contribute one of the first longitudinal accounts of creative practitioners' evolving relationships with AI, advance a theoretical perspective of technology adoption as ongoing identity and value negotiation, and offer design implications for supporting control, diverse modes of collaboration, and the creative potential of failure. These contributions are situated within the specific platform and IP realities of the Chinese ecosystem. Together, these contributions deepen our understanding of how generative AI reshapes creative practice. They also point to future directions for designing systems that respect and sustain human creativity across diverse global contexts.

Acknowledgments

The authors thank all participants for their time, openness, and continued commitment throughout the five-year study. We also appreciate the constructive feedback provided by colleagues during earlier drafts of this work. This research did not receive any specific grant from funding agencies in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors.

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A Participant Demographics

A.1 Baseline Demographics in 2021

Table 1: Summary of Participant Demographics (Baseline in 2021, $N = 17$).

ID	Age (2021)	Gender	Education	Urban/Rural	Years of Drawing	Professional Status
1	22	F	Bachelor	Urban	2	Professional
2	24	F	Bachelor	Urban	6	Professional
3	22	M	Bachelor	Rural	7	Professional
4	19	M	Master	Urban	3	Non-professional
5	33	F	Master	Urban	11	Professional
6	26	F	Master	Urban	8	Professional
7	34	M	Bachelor	Rural	8	Professional (later attrition)
8	31	M	Master	Urban	7	Professional (attrition after 2022)
9	29	F	Bachelor	Rural	8	Professional
10	26	M	Bachelor	Urban	8	Non-professional → Professional
11	26	F	High School	Rural	7	Professional
12	25	F	Master	Urban	7	Non-professional
13	33	M	Bachelor	Urban	8	Non-professional
14	22	F	Bachelor	Rural	7	Non-professional
15	27	M	Bachelor	Rural	9	Professional
16	24	F	Bachelor	Rural	11	Professional (attrition)
17	24	F	Master	Rural	6	Non-professional (attrition)

A.2 Detailed Participant Information (2021–2025)

Table 2: Participant creative domains, client types, and professional status across five annual waves (2021–2025).

ID	2021			2022			2023			2024			2025		
	Field	Client	Prof.	Field	Client	Prof.	Field	Client	Prof.	Field	Client	Prof.	Field	Client	Prof.
1	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y
2	Illustration	Small Co.	Y	Illustration	Small Co.	Y	Illustration	Small Co.	Y	Illustration	Small Co.	Y	Concept Design	Private	Y
3	Concept Design	Private	Y	Concept Design	Private	Y	Concept Design	Private	Y	–	–	–	–	–	–
4	–	–	N	–	–	N	Concept Design	–	N	Concept Design	–	N	Concept Design	–	N
5	Animation	Large Co.	Y	Animation	Large Co.	Y	–	–	–	Animation	Large Co.	Y	Animation	Large Co.	Y
6	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y
7	Illustration	Small Co.	Y	Illustration	Small Co.	Y	Illustration	–	N	Illustration	–	N	Illustration	–	N
8	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	–	N	Game Art	–	N	Game Art	–	N
9	Animation	Large Co.	Y	Animation	Large Co.	Y	Animation	–	N	Illustration	Small Co.	Y	Illustration	Small Co.	Y
10	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y	Game Art	Large Co.	Y
11	Concept Design	Small Co.	Y	Concept Design	Small Co.	Y	Concept Design	Small Co.	Y	Concept Design	Small Co.	Y	Concept Design	Small Co.	Y
12	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N
13	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N
14	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N	Digital Art	–	N
15	Graphic Design	Publisher	Y	Graphic Design	Publisher	Y	Graphic Design	Publisher	Y	Graphic Design	Publisher	Y	Graphic Design	Publisher	Y
16	Animation	Large Co.	Y	–	–	–	Animation	Large Co.	Y	–	–	–	–	–	–
17	Digital Art	–	N	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

B Questionnaire Items (0–10 Scale)

C Interview Guide

The following semi-structured interview guide was used to collect qualitative data. Questions were organized into four thematic blocks: (1) Background Information, (2) Experience with Generative AI, (3) Attitudes toward Generative AI, and (4) Forward-looking Reflections. Probes were used where appropriate to elicit more detailed responses.

C.1 Background Information

- (1) Age
- (2) Years of artistic practice
- (3) Living context: urban / rural
- (4) Primary artistic domain (e.g., commercial/original/published illustration; concept design for characters/scenes/props;

Table 3: Survey Items Used in Quantitative Analysis (0–10 Likert Scale)

Item	Survey Question
Q1	I consider myself knowledgeable about the basic concepts and working principles of generative AI.
Q2	I frequently use generative AI tools in my creative work.
Q3	I think AI can reproduce some aspects of artistic style or expression.
Q4	I view generative AI as a tool that can assist creative work.
Q5	I think AI can provide creative references or new sources of inspiration.
Q6	I am willing to spend time learning how to use generative AI effectively.
Q7	Using AI may lead to homogenization of artworks and reduce individual style.
Q8	Using AI does not necessarily make artists more competitive professionally.
Q9	The widespread use of AI may reduce market demand or affect artists' career development.
Q10	The copyright and authorship of AI-generated works are important issues that need clarification.
Q11	I have a general view, either favorable or skeptical, about the future of AI-assisted creation in digital art.
Q12	Overall, I tend to have a positive attitude toward applying generative AI to creative work.

comics/graphic novels/animation; game art; digital art; graphic design; other)

- (5) Professional status (e.g., freelance artist, employee, studio founder, part-time artist, student, unemployed)
- (6) Client type (e.g., individual clients, galleries, publishers, small companies, medium/large companies, none)

C.2 Experience with Generative AI

- (1) Familiarity with generative AI (e.g., no knowledge, basic awareness, entry-level user, intermediate user, advanced user)
- (2) Have you ever used AI tools in your creative process?
- (3) Which AI tools have you used?
- (4) At which stages of creation have you used AI? (e.g., ideation, early references, sketching, composition, rendering, post-processing, direct image generation)
- (5) How have you integrated AI content into your work? (e.g., inspiration only, redraw based on reference, modify base image, partial use, minor adjustments, direct adoption)

C.3 Attitudes toward Generative AI

- (1) Do you think AI can significantly improve work efficiency?
- (2) Has AI helped you overcome creative bottlenecks?
- (3) Has AI lowered the technical barriers for artistic creation?
- (4) Can someone proficient in AI be considered an “artist”?
- (5) Do AI-generated works have artistic value?

- (6) Is “AI art” a new category of art?

- (7) Is emotional expression something that AI can never replace?
- (8) Is it unethical to train models on data without authorization?
- (9) Should artists have the right to decide whether their works are used for training?
- (10) Should copyright of AI-generated works belong to the user?
- (11) Should AI-assisted works be priced lower?
- (12) Will generative AI have disruptive impacts on the industry?
- (13) Is AI mainly a threat to lower-tier commercial art?
- (14) Will proficiency with AI become an essential skill?
- (15) Will the value of purely hand-drawn works increase?
- (16) Do you feel excited and optimistic about AI's development?
- (17) Do you feel anxious or uneasy about the rise of AI?
- (18) Do you feel pressured to learn new technologies because of AI?

C.4 Forward-looking Reflections

- (1) What do you see as the greatest opportunities brought by AI?
- (2) What are the greatest challenges AI poses (or is expected to pose) for artists?
- (3) What do you see as the most urgent ethical and copyright issues, and what solutions would you propose?
- (4) What expectations do you have for industry platforms?
- (5) What would you like to say to artists who reject AI and to those who fully rely on it?
- (6) Other open comments